

Heads or modifiers: Family names and number marking in Spanish

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Abstract In environments where nouns require plural marking in Spanish, family names can remain uninflected: *muchos herreros* ‘many smiths’, but *muchos Herrero(s)* ‘many Herreros’. I propose that *muchos Herrero* has a different syntactic representation than *muchos Herreros* on the basis of the semantic contrast between *los Herrero*, which can be interpreted as ‘the (unrelated) Herreros’ or ‘the (related) Herreros’, and *los Herreros*, which can only be interpreted as ‘the (unrelated) Herreros’. The family name does not inflect for number in *muchos/los Herrero* because it is a modifier of an elided head noun, and the ambiguity of *los Herrero*, or *los Ø Herrero*, stems from the multiple possible identities of this noun. If *los Herrero* contains the light, or rootless, noun PEOPLE, it has the reading ‘the (unrelated) Herreros’, and if it contains a silent kinship term like *familiares* ‘relatives’, *hermanos* ‘siblings’, or *primos* ‘cousins’, it has the reading ‘the (related) Herreros’. In support of this analysis, I show that constructions in which this kinship term is overt, such as *los primos Herrero* ‘the Herrero cousins’, display the prosodic, semantic, and syntactic properties of a single extended nominal projection and not those of two referential expressions in apposition. Finally, I argue that the family name takes the plural suffix in *muchos/los Herreros* because it is the head of the noun phrase in this case. Since there is no position available for a covert kinship term in *los Herreros*, it follows that this construction can only mean ‘the (unrelated) Herreros’.

Keywords: names, number, modification, light nouns, predicativism, associativity

1 Introduction

In Spanish, given names and family names can both be pluralized, as in (1), to convey that more than one individual bears the same name (Fernández Leboranz 1999, Real Academia Española 2009, Saab & Lo Guercio 2020, Camacho 2021, Fábregas 2021).

- (1) a. Hay varios Alejandros en la lista de invitados.
has several Alejandros on the list of guests
‘There are several Alejandros on the guest list.’
b. Hay varios Herreros en la lista de invitados.
has several Herreros on the list of guests
‘There are several Herreros on the guest list.’

Curiously, plural marking can be omitted on family names provided that there is an accompanying determiner, numeral, or quantifier (Alcina Franch & Bleca 1975, Fernández Leboranz 1999, Real Academia Española 2009, Saab & Lo Guercio 2020, Camacho 2021). For example, uninflected *Herrero* is possible in (2a), where it is preceded by the quantifier *varios* ‘several’, but not in (2b), where it occurs as a bare argument.

- (2) a. Hay varios {Herreros / Herrero} en la lista de invitados.
has several Herreros Herrero on the list of guests
‘There are several Herreros on the guest list.’
b. Hay {Herreros / *Herrero} en la lista de invitados.
has Herreros Herrero on the list of guests
‘There are Herreros on the guest list.’

Plural marking cannot, however, be omitted on given names irrespective of whether they are introduced by a determiner, as in (3a), or not, as in (3b).

- (3) a. Hay varios {Alejandros / *Alejandro} en la lista de invitados.
has several Alejandros Alejandro on the list of guests
‘There are several Alejandros on the guest list.’
b. Hay {Alejandros / *Alejandro} en la lista de invitados.
has Alejandros Alejandro on the list of guests
‘There are Alejandros on the guest list.’

The contrast between *varios Herrero* ‘several Herreros’ and **varios Alejandro* ‘several Alejandros’ is the first of two number-related phenomena that I investigate in this paper.

The second relates to the semantic difference between *los Herrero*, which can have the reading ‘the (unrelated) Herreros’ or ‘the (related) Herreros’, and *los Herreros*, which can only have the reading ‘the (unrelated) Herreros’ (Alcina Franch & Bleca 1975, Romero Gualda 1989, Fernández Leboranz 1999, Real Academia Española 2009, Camacho 2021). To illustrate this point, *los Herrero* is interchangeable with *los Herreros* in (4a), where the referents are unrelated, but not in (4b), where they are father and son.

- (4) a. Los {Herrero / Herreros}, que no tienen parentesco, trabajan juntos.
the Herrero Herreros that not have.3PL relation work.3PL together
‘The Herreros, who are unrelated, work together.’

- b. Los {Herrero / #Herreros}, padre e hijo, trabajan juntos.
 the Herrero Herreros father and son work.3PL together
 ‘The Herreros, father and son, work together.’

It can, furthermore, be demonstrated that the construction *los Herrero* is limited to family names. Even if two individuals who have the same given name are related, as in (5), the plural suffix is obligatory (Camacho 2021).

- (5) Los {Alejandros / *Alejandro}, padre e hijo, trabajan juntos.
 the Alejandros Alejandro father and son work.3PL together
 ‘The Alejandros, father and son, work together.’

These additional facts raise the question of whether *los Herrero* maps onto more than one structure since it has more than one interpretation and also why *los Herrero* is grammatical when **los Alejandro* ‘the Alejandro’ is not.

In broad strokes, the analysis of names that I develop in this article can be summarized as follows. Given names and family names can both head the noun phrase, in which they can be pluralized like a noun. This type of configuration is given in (6), where I assign the plural marker -s to Borer’s (2005) division phrase (DivP).¹

- (6) a. [QP *varios* [DivP -s [nP *Alejandro*]]]
 ‘several Alejandros’
 b. [QP *varios* [DivP -s [nP *Herrero*]]]
 ‘several Herreros’

Family names can also modify the head of the noun phrase, and though I agree with Fábregas (2021) that they are best represented as prepositional phrases in Spanish, I maintain that the preposition itself is never phonologically realized, as indicated in (7).

- (7) [QP *varios* [DivP Ø] [PP Ø [nP *Herrero*]]]
 ‘several Herrero ones’

The quantifier *varios* ‘several’ is plural in form because there is an elided plural noun in DivP, just as there is in a construction like *varios de hierro* ‘several iron ones’. The family name *Herrero*, on the other hand, does not inflect for number because it is a PP modifier, one that serves to narrow down the set of possible referents.

I extend the general structure in (7) to *los Herrero* ‘the (unrelated or related) Herreros’ and attribute the ambiguity of this expression to a contentless versus contentful noun in DivP. When the covert noun lacks a root, as in (8a), the referents of *los Herrero* are taken to be unrelated, and when the covert noun is a kinship term like *familiares* ‘relatives’, as in (8b), the referents are taken to be related.

- (8) a. [DP *los* [DivP Ø] [PP Ø [nP *Herrero*]]]
 ‘the Herrero ones’
 b. [DP *los* [DivP *familiares*] [PP Ø [nP *Herrero*]]]
 ‘the Herrero relatives’

The reason that *los Herreros* ‘the (unrelated) Herreros’ has but one reading is that the pluralized family name occupies DivP in (9), thereby preventing a kinship term from appearing in this position.

¹ One could, alternatively, assign -s to Ritter’s (1991, 1992) number phrase (NumP).

- (9) $[_{DP} \text{ los } [_{DivP} \text{ -s } [_{nP} \text{ Herrero}]]]$
 ‘the Herreros’

This configuration is semantically equivalent to that in (8a), hence the possibility of using *los Herrero* or *los Herreros* when the individuals in question are unrelated.

In recent work, Camacho (2021) attributes the distinct morphosyntactic and semantic behaviour of family names in Spanish to the phenomenon of associative plurality, and in section 2 of this paper, I identify several empirical and theoretical issues with this approach. In section 3, I motivate the claim that family names are modifiers of given names and show that they do not exhibit the properties of compound-internal elements or *aP* modifiers, all of which bolsters Fábregas’s (2021) view that they are PP modifiers in Spanish. In section 4, I explore the internal structure of names and how each step of the derivation translates to phonological and logical form. In section 5, I argue that there is an unpronounced head noun in *los Herrero* ‘the (unrelated or related) Herreros’ but not in *los Herreros* ‘the (unrelated) Herreros’ and demonstrate how this proposal explains the ambiguity of *los Herrero*. In section 6, I address several open questions, including the representation of complex family names, the invariable forms of family names that end in the patronymic suffix *-ez*, and reference to the members of dynastic families. Lastly, in section 7, I recapitulate the analysis and conclude.

2 Associativity and family names

To explain why the definite article is plural in form and the family name is not in *los Herrero* ‘the (unrelated or related) Herreros’, Camacho (2021) posits that associative rather than additive, or canonical, plurality is at play. To evaluate this possibility, it is informative to first consider a language like Hungarian where this distinction is expressed morphologically. As illustrated in (10), the noun *ügyvéd* ‘lawyer’ can occur with the additive plural suffix *-ek* or the associative plural suffix *-ék* (Corbett & Mithun 1996; Corbett 2000; Moravcsik 2003a,b; Cinque 2018; Dékány 2021; den Dikken 2023).²

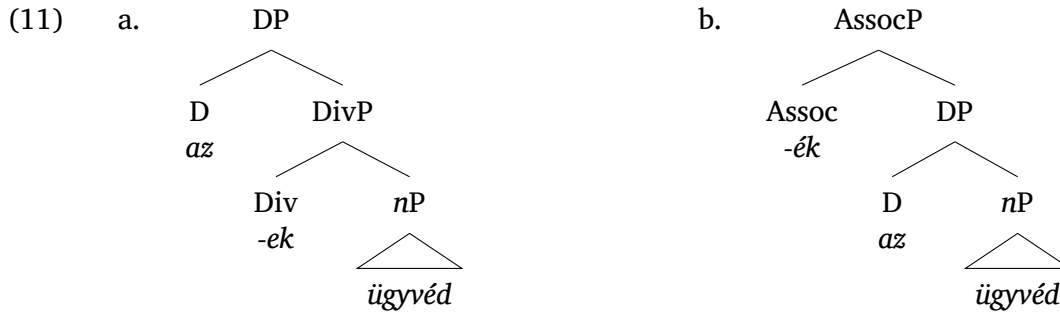
- (10) a. *Az ügyvéd-ek tárgyalták az ítélet-et.*
 the lawyer-PL discussed.3PL.DEF the verdict.ACC
 ‘The lawyers were discussing the verdict.’
 b. *Az ügyvéd-ék tárgyalták az ítélet-et.*
 the lawyer-ASSOC discussed.3PL.DEF the verdict.ACC
 ‘The lawyer and her/his/their associates were discussing the verdict.’

Every individual in the extension of *az ügyvédek* ‘the lawyers’ is necessarily a lawyer, so this expression has homogeneous reference. Every individual in the extension of *az ügyvédék* ‘the lawyer and her/his/their associates’, in contrast, is not necessarily a lawyer, so this expression has heterogeneous reference. For instance, the associates of the focal referent in (10b) could be a paralegal and a legal secretary.

An established view in the literature on number is that additive plural morphology like *-ek* corresponds to a position below D and that associative plural morphology like *-ék* corresponds to a position above D (Hirose 2004; Ueda & Haraguchi 2008; Nakanishi & Ritter 2009; Görgülü 2011; Forbes 2013; Biswas 2014; Cinque 2018; Ghomeshi & Francis Holness 2018; Forbes 2019; Dékány 2021; Lewis 2021, 2023, 2024, 2025). Accordingly, one could represent *az ügyvédek* ‘the lawyers’ as in (11a), where *-ek* spells out Div, and

² I thank Éva Dékány and Angelika Kiss for extensive discussion of the Hungarian data.

az ügyvédék ‘the lawyer and her/his/their associates’ as in (11b), where *-ék* spells out the head of an associative plural phrase (AssocP).³



The relative ordering of pluralization and definiteness predicts that additive plurals will have a different interpretation than associative plurals. In the first structure, Div pluralizes the *nP*, and D returns a unique maximal sum of individuals who are lawyers. In the second structure, D returns a unique individual who is a lawyer, and Assoc relates this individual to others, who could be lawyers as well but need not be. That is, additive plural morphology applies to predicates and yields homogeneous reference, while associative plural morphology applies to individuals and yields heterogeneous reference. In support of this point, the definite article can be omitted in (12a) but not in (12b).

- (12) a. (Az) ügyvéd-ek tárgyalták az ítéletet.
the lawyer-PL discussed.3PL.DEF the verdict.ACC
‘(The) lawyers were discussing the verdict.’
- b. *(Az) ügyvéd-ék tárgyalták az ítéletet.
the lawyer-ASSOC discussed.3PL.DEF the verdict.ACC
‘The lawyer and her/his/their associates were discussing the verdict.’

As these facts confirm, the additive plural suffix *-ek* combines directly with the noun *ügyvéd* ‘lawyer’, while that the associative plural suffix *-ék* combines with the definite description *az ügyvéd* ‘the lawyer’, or the focal referent.

Additive plural morphology is widely taken to lexicalize Link’s (1983) star operator (*), which generates the algebraic closure of a predicate, or all possible sums of the elements in its extension. In a world where the only lawyers are Ágnes (*a*), Béla (*b*), and Csilla (*c*), the predicates Lawyer and *Lawyer can be represented as in (13).⁴

³ Following Hirose (2004), possessive marking in Hungarian provides independent evidence that additive plurality occupies a lower functional projection than associative plurality. In possessive constructions, such as those in (i), additive plural morphology takes a different form, *-i*, and appears inside of the underlined suffix that indexes the possessor, whereas associative plural morphology has the same form, *-ék*, and appears outside of the suffix that indexes the possessor.

- (i) a. Az ügyvéd-e-i-m tárgyalták az ítéletet.
the lawyer-POSS-PL-POSS.1SG discussed.3PL.DEF the verdict.ACC
‘My lawyers were discussing the verdict.’
- b. Az ügyvéd-em-ék tárgyalták az ítéletet.
the lawyer-POSS.1SG-ASSOC discussed.3PL.DEF the verdict.ACC
‘My lawyer and her/his/their associates were discussing the verdict.’

⁴ The inclusion of atoms in the extension of *Lawyer is known as the inclusive approach to plurality (Krifka 1989, Schwarzschild 1996, Van Geenhoven 2000, Farkas & de Swart 2003, Krifka 2003, Sauerland 2003, Sauerland et al. 2005, Spector 2007, Zweig 2009, Chierchia 2010, Farkas & de Swart 2010, Grimm 2013).

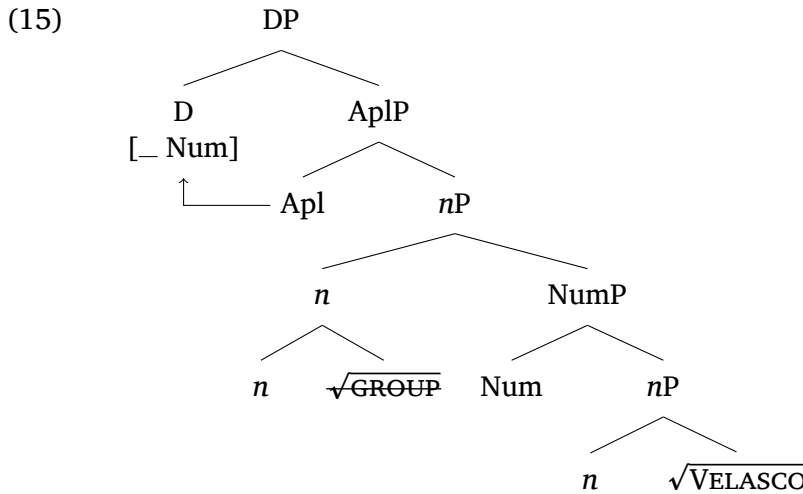
- (13) a. Lawyer = {*a*, *b*, *c*}
 b. *Lawyer = {*a*, *b*, *c*, *a* ⊕ *b*, *a* ⊕ *c*, *b* ⊕ *c*, *a* ⊕ *b* ⊕ *c*}

Since the extensions of additive plural nouns like *ügyvédek* ‘lawyers’ are derived entirely from those of their singular counterparts, they must have homogeneous reference. As for associative plural morphology, many semantic accounts converge on the notion that it is sensitive to the context (Kratzer 2009, Nakanishi & Ritter 2009, Görgülü 2011, Tatsumi 2017, New 2021, Hucklebridge 2023). For example, Kratzer (2009: 224) proposes the [GROUP] feature in (14a), and Nakanishi & Ritter (2009: 4) incorporate this feature into the denotation of *-tati*, the associative plural suffix in Japanese, in (14b).

- (14) a. $\llbracket [\text{GROUP}] \rrbracket^{g,c} = \lambda x_e . \text{group}(x)(c)$
 b. $\llbracket \text{-tati} \rrbracket^c = \lambda x_e : x \text{ is human} . \text{group}(x)(c)$

Both are functions of semantic type $\langle e, e \rangle$ that take an individual *x*, the focal referent, and return a contextually dependent group of individuals of which *x* is a member. It follows that associative plural constructions like *az ügyvédék* ‘the lawyer and her/his/their associates’ have heterogeneous reference because the set of associates is determined by their relation to the focal referent and not by any sort of property that they have in common. The core insight, and one that is echoed in much of the syntactic literature on associative plurality, is that the focal referent is established before the set of associates.

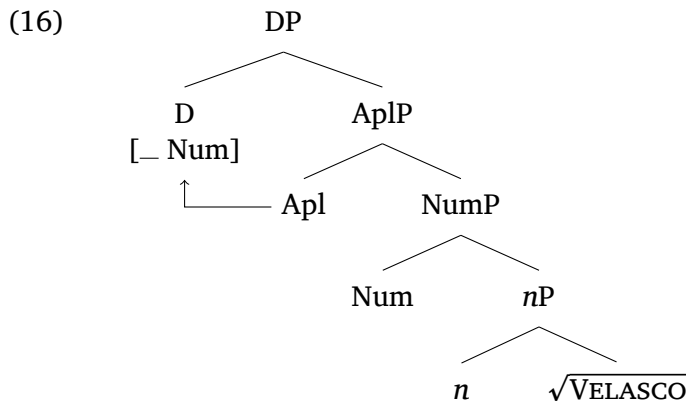
Returning to Spanish, Camacho (2021) argues that this language expresses associative plurality through constructions like *los Velasco* ‘the (unrelated or related) Velascos’ in both of their possible readings even though there is no identifiable focal referent and, consequently, no individual on which to base the set of associates. According to the proposed structure of *los Velasco* in (15), the family name in NumP is compounded with a silent noun, GROUP, and the resulting *n*P is then pluralized by AplP (AssocP), the projection that is responsible for the plural form of the definite article (Camacho 2021: 20).



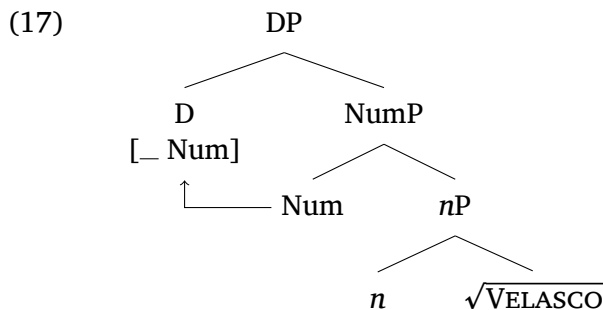
One immediate concern is the need for NumP in this configuration, especially if *Velasco* is a compound-internal element. For this author, NumP is the locus of additive plurality and is realized as *-s* in Spanish, yet there is no number marking on the family name in *los Velasco*. Another issue relates to the silent noun GROUP, which Camacho considers to have the same lexical entry as Kratzer’s (2009) [GROUP] feature in (14a) above. If GROUP is of type $\langle e, e \rangle$ and *Velasco* is of type $\langle e, t \rangle$, as are all NumPs in Spanish, neither expression is in the domain of the other, and functional application cannot take place.

At the same time, GROUP cannot be eliminated from this structure without losing the apparent explanation for the singular form of the family name in *los Velasco*. A third problem is the position of AplP below DP, where its sole purpose seems to be to value D as plural so that this head takes the form *los* ‘the’ rather than *el* ‘the’. After all, it is GROUP, and not Apl, that generates the set of associates in this account.

Even though *los Velascos* ‘the (unrelated) Velascos’ cannot be used to refer to the members of a family, [Camacho \(2021: 14\)](#) maintains that AplP (AssocP) is present in the structure of this expression in (16).



Since there is no relation among the referents of *los Velascos*, the question is why this construction could not have the simpler representation in (17), where D would still be spelled out as *los* ‘the’ through concord with Num.



One recurring theme in [Camacho’s](#) approach to family names is that they are always situated the lowest level of the noun phrase, either as a compound-internal modifier of the head noun, as in (15), or as the head noun itself, as in (16). In the next section, I present arguments that family names are modifiers in a more traditional sense and discuss their syntactic relation to given names in Spanish.

3 Family names as modifiers

How given names comes to refer to their bearers is a topic of extensive debate in linguistics and philosophy, yet there is consensus that they are generated in the same structural position as nouns ([Longobardi 1994](#), [Geurts 1997](#), [Thomsen 1997](#), [Chierchia 1998](#), [Longobardi 2001](#), [Borer 2005](#), [Elbourne 2005](#), [Longobardi 2005](#), [Matushansky 2006](#), [Longobardi 2008](#), [Matushansky 2008](#), [Ghomeshi & Massam 2009](#), [Izumi 2012](#), [Fara 2015a](#), [Matushansky 2015](#), [Muñoz 2019](#), [Baggio & Cairncross 2020](#), [Saab & Lo Guercio 2020](#), [Camacho 2021](#), [Jambrović 2021](#), [Saab 2021](#), [Jambrović 2024](#), [Oggiani & Aguilar Gue-](#)

vara 2024). A different, yet related, issue is where to assign family names that occur together with given names, as in (18).

- (18) Alejandro Herrero me saludó.
 Alejandro Herrero 1SG greeted.3SG
 ‘Alejandro Herrero greeted me.’

A survey of family names in Spanish suggests that they originally served to clarify the intended referent of a given name by introducing additional content into the noun phrase.

In many languages, family names are often identical to other lexical items, such as adjectives and nouns that denote concrete properties, and Spanish is no exception. For instance, the family names in (19) correspond to adjectives that express physical traits or places of origin, and those in (20) correspond to nouns that express occupations or geographical features, both natural and artificial.

- | | |
|---|--|
| <p>(19) a. Bello (<i>bello</i> ‘beautiful’)
 b. Calvo (<i>calvo</i> ‘bald’)
 c. Delgado (<i>delgado</i> ‘thin’)
 d. Gallego (<i>gallego</i> ‘Galician’)
 e. Leal (<i>leal</i> ‘loyal’)
 f. Moreno (<i>moreno</i> ‘dark’)
 g. Navarro (<i>navarro</i> ‘Navarrese’)
 h. Rubio (<i>rubio</i> ‘blond’)
 i. Sevillano (<i>sevillano</i> ‘Sevillian’)</p> | <p>(20) a. Arroyo (<i>arroyo</i> ‘stream’)
 b. Bosque (<i>bosque</i> ‘forest’)
 c. Escudero (<i>escudero</i> ‘squire’)
 d. Flores (<i>flores</i> ‘flowers’)
 e. Guerrero (<i>guerrero</i> ‘warrior’)
 f. Huerta (<i>huerta</i> ‘garden’)
 g. Montero (<i>montero</i> ‘hunter’)
 h. Pastor (<i>pastor</i> ‘shepherd’)
 i. Roca (<i>roca</i> ‘rock’)</p> |
|---|--|

In the same vein, the family names in (21) correspond to prepositional phrases whose nominal component refers to a location or an entity that has religious significance.

- (21) a. de la Cruz (*de la cruz* ‘of the cross’)
 b. de Dios (*de Dios* ‘of God’)
 c. de la Fuente (*de la fuente* ‘of the fountain’)
 d. de Jesús (*de Jesús* ‘of Jesus’)
 e. de León (*de León* ‘of León’)
 f. del Río (*del río* ‘of the river’)
 g. de los Santos (*de los santos* ‘of the saints’)
 h. de la Torre (*de la torre* ‘of the tower’)
 i. del Valle (*del valle* ‘of the valley’)

Any of the words or phrases in parentheses in (19) through (21) could be used to disambiguate two or more individuals who have the same given name, as illustrated in (22) with *moreno* ‘dark-haired’ and *rubio* ‘light-haired’, so it is unsurprising that they evolved into family names.

- (22) Me refiero al Juan moreno, no al Juan rubio.
 1SG refer.1SG to.the Juan brunette not to.the Juan blond
 ‘I am referring to the dark-haired Juan, not the light-haired Juan.’

A process of semantic change was, moreover, inevitable as these and other family names were passed down through the generations and their descriptive content was no longer necessarily true of their bearers.

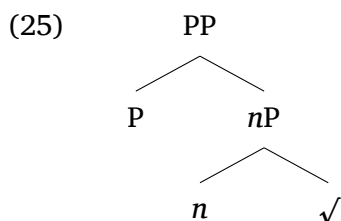
Another source of family names in Spanish are patronymics, which were formed by adding the suffix *-ez* to the base of a given name. As Fábregas (2021: 16) observes in (23), the stressed syllable of a patronymic reflects the stressed syllable of the base.

- (23) a. Ad[á]n → Ad[á]nez
 b. Dom[i]ngo → Dom[í]nguez
 c. [Í]ñigo → [Í]ñiguez

Patronymic family names constitute the vast majority of lexical items in Spanish that end in *-z* and do not have word-final stress. There is, for example, another *-ez* suffix that derives nouns from adjectives and does displace stress, as indicated in (24).

- (24) a. estr[e]cho → estrech[e]z
 narrow narrowness
 b. r[í]gido → rigid[e]z
 rigid rigidity

In light of the phonological contrast between the family names in (23) and the nouns in (24), Fábregas (2021: 35) argues that patronymic *-ez* is not a typical derivational suffix but rather a prepositional element such that a family name like *Domínguez* has the structure in (25).



In section 4, I contend that patronymic *-ez* is a nominal suffix and offer an alternative explanation for its inability to attract stress. I do, nevertheless, concur with Fábregas that when family names appear with given names in Spanish, they are most suitably represented as PP modifiers, even if it means positing a covert preposition. One need look no further than the names of Spanish Golden Age authors to find evidence that *de* ‘of’ was often used to link family names to given names: *Guillén de Castro y Mateo*, *Miguel de Cervantes Saavedra*, *Alonso de Ercilla y Zúñiga*, *Luis de Góngora y Argote*, *Fernando de Herrera*, *Lope de Rueda*, and *María de Zayas Sotomayor*.

One might ask whether the combination of a given name and a family name could be a type of noun-noun compound in Spanish. The challenge for this view is that it is customary for individuals to have two given names in addition to two family names, yet noun-noun compounds do not permit more than two elements, as revealed by *perro policía* ‘police dog’ versus **perro policía mascota* ‘pet police dog’ (Piera 1995: 307). In the case of a name like *Gabriel José García Márquez*, it would be viable to analyze *Gabriel José* as a compound, but not *Gabriel José García* or *Gabriel José García Márquez*.⁵ It can even be demonstrated syntactically that family names are independent from given names in a way that two given names are not. As Fábregas (2021: 23) notes, one could differentiate two

⁵ *Gabriel José* cannot, however, be the same type of compound as *perro policía* based on morphological and phonological factors. First, the preferred plural form of *Gabriel José* is *Gabriel Josés*, whereas that of *perro policía* is *perros policía* ‘police dogs’. Second, as Fábregas (2021) remarks, only the latter element of a complex given name receives primary stress: *Gabriel Jos[é]*, not **Gabri[e]l Jos[é]*. On the other hand, both elements of a noun-noun compound receive primary stress: *p[e]rro polic[í]a*.

women named María José Fernández and María Dolores Pérez by contrastively focusing their family names, as in (26a), but not the second of their given names, as in (26b).

- (26) a. María, no Fernández sino Pérez
 María not Fernández but Pérez
 ‘María, not Fernández but Pérez’
- b. *María, no José sino Dolores
 María not José but Dolores
 Literal: ‘María, not José but Dolores’

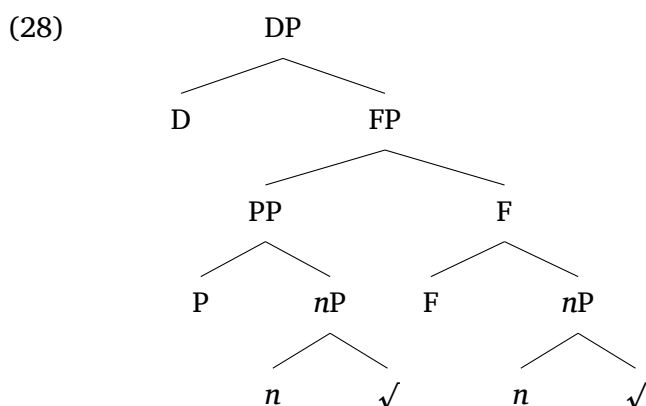
These data suggest that family names are typical modifiers and that second given names are compound-internal elements.

Family names in Spanish cannot be construed as *aP* modifiers either because they do not display sensitivity to the gender of their bearers. At first glance, *Herrero/Herrera*, *Rivero/Rivera*, and *Romero/Romera* seem to constitute inflectional pairs, yet they do not behave as such. In (27), which could be the opening lines of written or electronic correspondence, the inferred gender of the referent determines the form of the adjective *estimado/estimada* ‘esteemed’ but does not exclude the possibility of *Herrero* or *Herrera* as the family name.⁶

- (27) a. {Estimado / #Estimada} Alejandro {Herrero / Herrera}, ¿cómo está?
 esteemed esteemed.F Alejandro Herrero Herrera how are.3SG
 ‘Dear Alejandro Herrero/Herrera, how are you (formal)?’
- b. {#Estimado / Estimada} Alejandra {Herrero / Herrera}, ¿cómo está?
 esteemed esteemed.F Alejandra Herrero Herrera how are.3SG
 ‘Dear Alejandra Herrero/Herrera, how are you (formal)?’

Even though *Herrero* and *Herrera* share a root, as do the nouns *herrero* ‘smith’ and *herrera* ‘(female) smith’, the grammar of Spanish does not treat them as masculine and feminine versions of the same name but rather as different names altogether.

The complete structure that Fábregas (2021: 36) proposes for sequences of given and family names follows in (28), where the given name is the head of the noun phrase and the family name is a PP modifier that merges as the specifier of a functional phrase (FP), as in Cinque’s (2005, 2010) work on the extended nominal projection.



⁶ It bears mentioning that there are languages where at least some family names do pattern like *aP* modifiers. In Polish, those that end in *-ski/-ska* necessarily reflect the inferred gender of the referent: *Dominik Kowalski*/*#Kowalska* and *Dominika Kowalska*/*#Kowalski*.

Given names precede family names in Spanish, so some type of movement is needed, but I disagree with Fábregas that the landing site of given names is D or its specifier. As Jambrović (2025: 34) shows in (29) through (31), there is no evidence that any type of name can raise above a prenominal adjective and occupy D in this language.

- (29) a. El viejo Juan por fin llamó.
the old Juan finally called.3SG
'Old Juan finally called.'
- b. *Juan viejo por fin llamó.
old Juan finally called.3SG
Intended: 'Old Juan finally called.'
- (30) a. La antigua Roma fue la ciudad más importante del Mediterráneo.
the ancient Rome was the city more important of.the Mediterranean
'Ancient Rome was the most important city of the Mediterranean.'
- b. *Roma antigua fue la ciudad más importante del Mediterráneo.
Rome ancient was the city more important of.the Mediterranean
Intended: 'Ancient Rome was the most important city of the Mediterranean.'
- (31) a. El pasado {jueves / mayo} fue un {día / mes} terrible.
the last Thursday May was a day month terrible
'Last Thursday/May was a terrible day/month.'
- b. *{Jueves / Mayo} pasado fue un {día / mes} terrible.
Thursday May last was a day month terrible
Intended: 'Last Thursday/May was a terrible day/month.'

Not only do these examples undermine Longobardi's (1994, 2001, 2005, 2008) claim that names move to D in all Romance languages, but they also raise the question of how names come to be referential as bare singular arguments.

One promising solution to the issue of bare singular names builds on the observation that some languages, including Catalan, have name-specific determiners (Ghomeshi & Massam 2009, Muñoz 2019, Izumi & Erickson 2021, Jambrović 2022). In (32), for instance, it is not the definite article that precedes the name *Pere* but a morphologically distinct element that is known as the personal article or proprial article (PROP) depending on the source (Longobardi 1994: 656).

- (32) a. el gos
the dog
'the dog'
- b. en Pere
PROP Pere
'Pere'

To differentiate the two types of determiners as vocabulary items, Ghomeshi & Massam (2009) consider the proprial article *en* in (33a) to have a [PROP(ER)] feature that the definite article *el* 'the' in (33b) lacks.

- (33) a. D_[PROP] ↔ /ən/
b. D ↔ /əl/

These authors extend the same analysis to languages where singular names appear bare by representing the proprial article as phonologically null. The Spanish equivalents of the Catalan determiners in (33) would, accordingly, be those in (34).

- (34) a. $D_{[PROP]} \leftrightarrow \emptyset$
 b. $D \leftrightarrow /el/$

Although Ghomeshi & Massam do not formalize the semantic contribution of [PROP], one could adopt Muñoz's (2019) proposal that the proprial article returns an expression that has the same referent across possible worlds, hence the rigidity of singular names that occur with the proprial article in Catalan and as bare arguments in Spanish.

A complication for this line of investigation is the optional use of the definite article with singular names in some varieties of Spanish (De Mello 1992, Fernández Leboranz 1999, Camacho 2019, Morera & Pérez Vigaray 2019, Saab & Lo Guercio 2020, Saab 2021, Caro Reina 2022, Oggiani & Aguilar Guevara 2024). It may, however, be the case that these varieties have repurposed the definite article as a proprial article, just as many North Germanic languages have done with third-person pronouns (Delsing 1993, Sigurðsson 2006, Johannessen & Garbacz 2014, Stausland Johnsen 2016, Kokkelmans 2018). From this perspective, the two determiners in (35) could be homophonous forms that lexicalize different features, as indicated by their glosses.

- (35) a. El abogado me saludó.
 the lawyer 1SG greeted.3SG
 'The lawyer greeted me'.
 b. El Alejandro me saludó.
 PROP Alejandro 1SG greeted.3SG
 'Alejandro greeted me'.

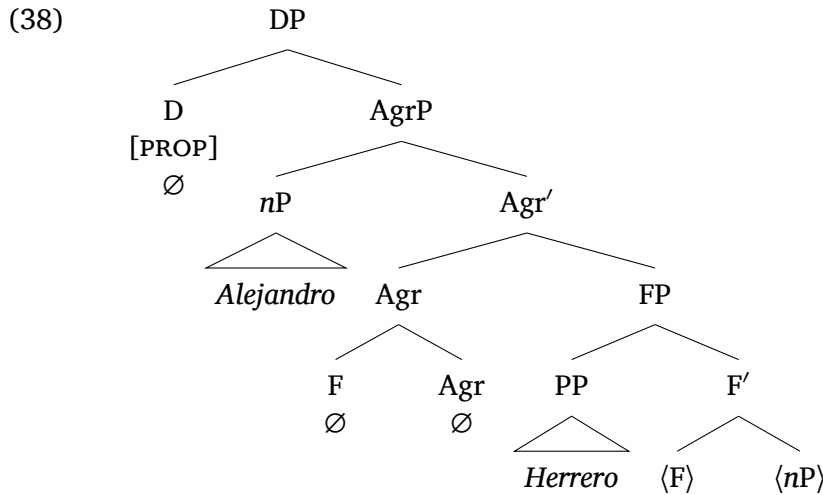
This approach finds support in Greek, where the article that is used with names is identical to the definite article in some varieties but not in others. The glosses that I have added to Panagiotidis's (2000: 731) data in (36) and (37) demonstrate the potential analogy between Spanish and Greek, though further research is needed.

- | | |
|--|---|
| <p>(36) Standard Greek</p> <p>a. o skilos
 the dog
 'the dog'</p> <p>b. o Yanis
 PROP Yanis
 'Yanis'</p> | <p>(37) Northern Greek</p> <p>a. u skilus
 the dog
 'the dog'</p> <p>b. i Yans
 PROP Yans
 'Yans'</p> |
|--|---|

The essential point is that there are ways to account for bare singular names in Spanish without resorting to *n*-to-D movement, a process for which there is no empirical basis.

To provide given names with a landing site other than D, I incorporate Cinque's (2005, 2010) view that an agreement phrase (AgrP) dominates every functional projection that introduces a modifier. In (38), for example, the given name *Alejandro* raises above the family name *Herrero* to occupy the specifier of AgrP, and the silent proprial article in D converts *Alejandro Herrero* into a referential expression.⁷

⁷ I assume, following Shlonsky (2004) and Kahnemuyipour (2014), that head movement of F to Agr triggers phrasal movement of the complement of F to the specifier of AgrP.



In favour of this structure, there are languages like Persian where the same grammatical material that appears between nouns and their modifiers also appears between given names and family names. For example, [Kahnemuyipour \(2014: 2\)](#) argues that the *ezāfe* (EZ), or linker, that precedes both of the adjectives in (39a) as well as the family name in (39b) is the phonological realization of the Agr head.⁸

- (39)
- a. sag-e qahveyi-ye gonde
dog-EZ brown-EZ big
'big, brown dog'
 - b. Ali-ye Mohammadi
Ali-EZ Mohammadi
'Ali Mohammadi'

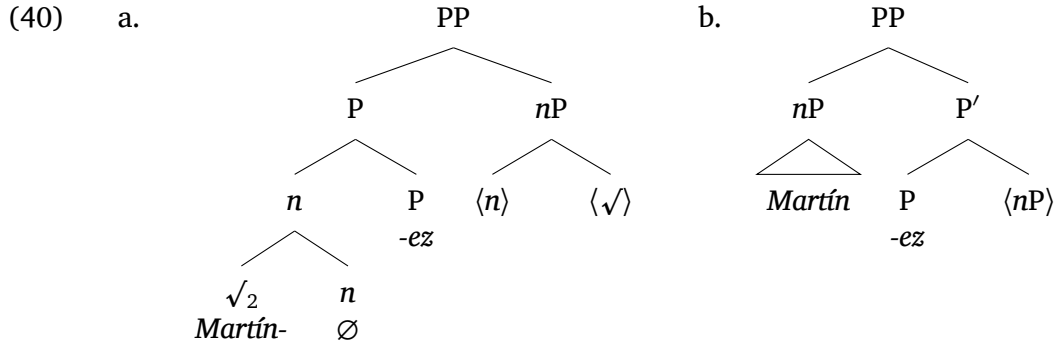
Even if one pursues a different analysis of *ezāfe*, the fact remains that family names exhibit the same syntactic properties as modifiers in Persian. In the next section, I examine the internal structure of given and family names and present a novel solution to the question of why the patronymic suffix *-ez* fails to attract stress in Spanish.

4 The internal structure of names

According to [Fábregas \(2021\)](#), the *-ez* of *Martínez* and other patronymic family names in Spanish lexicalizes a PP layer, as schematized in (25) above. The challenge for this approach is how to derive the position of *-ez* after the root without implementing head movement of *n* to P, as in (40a), which has not otherwise been posited in Spanish, or phrasal movement of *nP* to the specifier of PP, as in (40b), which would violate antilocality ([Abels 2003](#), [Grohmann 2003](#), [Bošković 2005](#), [Boeckx 2007](#)).⁹

⁸ Further evidence that *ezāfe* spells out Agr is found in the numerous Western Iranian languages where this element inflects for features like gender, number, definiteness, and case ([Holmberg & Odden 2008](#), [Samvelian 2008](#), [Toosarvandani & van Urk 2014](#), [Tahir 2018](#), [Kahnemuyipour & Peters 2019](#), [Gündoğdu et al. 2020](#), [Gündoğdu 2023](#), [Gündoğdu & Bulan 2023](#), [Gündoğdu & Erbası 2023](#), [Jambrović & Hassan 2023](#), [Peters et al. 2023](#), [Gündoğdu et al. 2024](#)).

⁹ I adhere to the tradition of modelling roots as numerical indices to represent the arbitrary connection between the form that they take and the interpretation that they receive in a particular syntactic environment ([Acquaviva 2009](#), [Pfau 2009](#), [Saab 2010](#), [Acquaviva & Panagiotidis 2012](#), [Acquaviva 2014](#), [Harley 2014](#), [Panagiotidis 2014](#)).

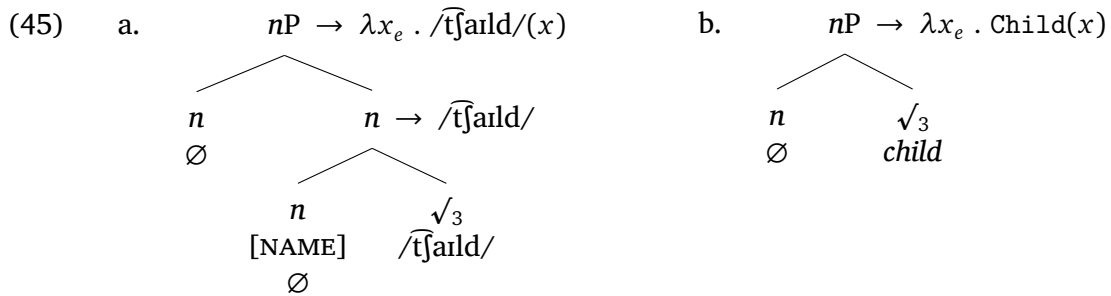


There is, consequently, theoretical motivation to consider other means of explaining why *-ez* does not displace the stress of the given name that serves as the base.

Crosslinguistically, names behave unexpectedly in ways that have long drawn the attention of linguists and psychologists. For instance, the family names in (41) through (44) all have regular plural forms in contrast to the nouns from which they are derived.

- | | |
|--|--|
| <p>(41) English (Kim et al. 1994: 184)</p> <p>a. Child → Childs</p> <p>b. child → children</p> | <p>(42) German (Marcus et al. 1995: 229)</p> <p>a. Wiese → Wieses</p> <p>b. Wiese → Wiesen ‘meadow(s)’</p> |
| <p>(43) Hebrew (Berent et al. 2002: 459)</p> <p>a. Barak → Barakim</p> <p>b. barak → brakim ‘lightning(s)’</p> | <p>(44) Hungarian (Pinker 1999: 233)</p> <p>a. Ló → Lók</p> <p>b. ló → lovak ‘horse(s)’</p> |

To account for this difference, Jambrović (2021, 2024) proposes that names minimally consist of two layers of nominalization: one to generate the phonological string that constitutes the name and another to generate a predicate that denotes the property of bearing this phonological string. As illustrated in (45), where I abstract away from head movement, the name *Child* and the noun *child* are both *nPs* of type $\langle e, t \rangle$, but they do not express the same property.¹⁰

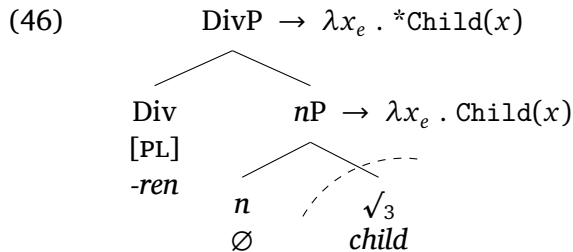


In prose, the name *Child* denotes a function that maps every individual x to the truth value 1 if and only if x is a $/tʃaɪld/$, and the noun *child* denotes a function that maps every individual x to the truth value 1 if and only if x is a child.

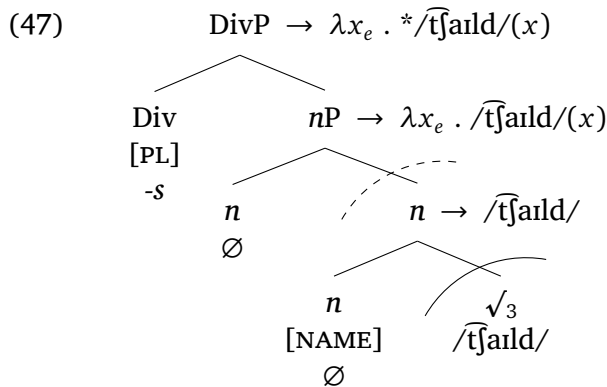
If, following Embick (2010), categorizers like *n* are phase heads and contextual allomorphy cannot take place across more than one phase boundary, the analysis in (45)

¹⁰ The view that names are property-denoting rather than individual-denoting expressions is known as predicativism (Sloat 1969; Burge 1973; Hornsby 1976; Bach 1981; Geurts 1997; Thomsen 1997; Bach 2002; Elbourne 2005; Matushansky 2006, 2008; Ghomeshi & Massam 2009; Sawyer 2010; Fara 2011; Izumi 2012; Fara 2015a,b; Matushansky 2015; Gray 2017, 2018; Muñoz 2019; Izumi & Erickson 2021; Jambrović 2022).

predicts that the irregular plural inflection of the noun *child* will not carry over to the name *Child*. In (46), the structure of *children*, the root is able to condition the realization of Div as *-ren* because there is a single phase boundary between these nodes.



In (47), the structure of *Childs*, the root is unable to condition the form of Div due to the second phase boundary, so the elsewhere plural suffix *-s* is inserted instead.



In this way, the higher *nP* in name predicates seals off the root from any functional projections that enter the derivation above this layer.

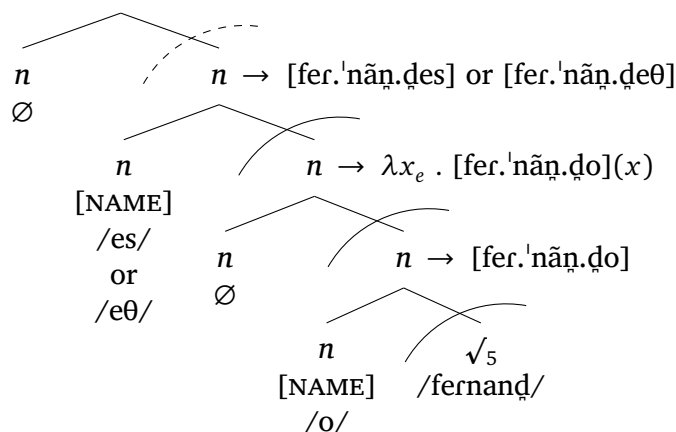
Having defended the claim that names are more internally complex than nouns, I return to the issue of patronymic family names in Spanish and the inability of *-ez* to attract stress. This phenomenon is especially puzzling when one factors in that the diminutive suffix *-ito/-ita* does attract stress in (48).

- (48)
- a. Fern[a]ndo → Fernand[i]to
Fernando Fernando.DIM
 - b. Fern[a]nda → Fernand[i]ta
Fernanda Fernanda.DIM

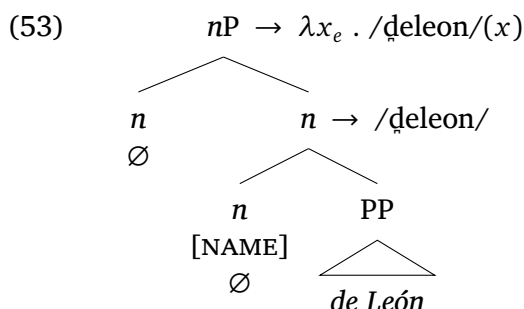
Since the interpretation of *-ito/-ita* is relatively predictable when it combines with given names, it is a “high” diminutive, or one that occupies a position above *nP* (De Belder et al. 2014). Accordingly, *Fernandito* can be represented as in (49), where *-ito* spells out the head of a diminutive phrase (DimP).¹¹

¹¹ Many authors who work in Distributed Morphology assign class markers like *-o* to theme nodes that are added postsyntactically to categorizers and functional heads (Oltra-Massuet 1999, Embick & Halle 2005, Oltra-Massuet & Arregi 2005, Embick & Noyer 2007, Embick 2010, Lampitelli 2014, Kramer 2015). Although I do not incorporate theme nodes into any structures, they are all compatible with this possibility.

(52) $nP \rightarrow \lambda x_{\rho} . [\text{fer.}^1 \text{n}\tilde{\text{a}}\text{n.des}](x)$ or $\lambda x_{\rho} . [\text{fer.}^1 \text{n}\tilde{\text{a}}\text{n.de}\theta](x)$



In section 3, I established that family names do not behave like compound-internal modifiers or *aP* modifiers when they appear with given names in Spanish, and based on these findings, I upheld Fábregas’s (2021) view that they are better analyzed as PP modifiers. At the same time, I do not consider patronymic *-ez*, or any other element, to spell out P and instead maintain that this head is never pronounced when it licenses family names as modifiers. As for the family names in (21) above that correspond to prepositional phrases, such as *de León*, they have all grammaticalized into phonological strings and have the representation in (53).¹³



¹³ This grammaticalization process becomes evident when asking speakers about the status of the preposition in a historical name like *Miguel de Cervantes*, where they take *de* ‘of’ to be independent from *Cervantes*, and a contemporary name like *Miguel de León*, where they take *de* to be inseparable from *León*.

5 Deriving *los Herrero* and *los Herreros*

In *Apuntaciones críticas sobre el lenguaje bogotano* (*Critical notes on the language of Bogotá*), *Cuervo* (1867: 61) takes up the issue of family names that do not inflect for number and makes the following remark:

Jamás se dará una explicación lógica y racional de la construcción *los Guevara* [...]; la que se ha intentado diciendo que antes del apellido se sobreentiende *señores* o cosa parecida, disculparía el plural de *los*, pero no bastaría para cohonestar el singular *Guevara*.

‘A logical and rational explanation will never be given for the construction *los Guevara* [...]; the one that has been attempted by saying that *señores* ‘gentlemen’ or something similar is implied before the family name would explain the plural of *los* ‘the’, but it would not be enough to justify the singular *Guevara*.’

That is, *Cuervo* does not find *los señores Guevara* ‘the Guevara gentlemen’ to be a viable means of explaining why the family name does not inflect for number in *los Guevara*. Along the same lines, *Camacho* (2021: 27) regards the expression *las hermanas Mirabal* ‘the Mirabal sisters’ as consisting of a kinship term and a family name in apposition and, for this reason, treats it separately from *las Mirabal* ‘the (unrelated or related) Mirabals’. This characterization of *las hermanas Mirabal* does not hold up to scrutiny, however, and in the first part of this section, I argue that the only difference between *las hermanas Mirabal* and *las Mirabal* is that the head noun is elided in the second case.

The incongruity in number that *Cuervo* (1867) mentions turns out to reveal a stark contrast between the genuine instance of apposition in (54a), where the second element must be plural in form, and the construction that involves the same kinship term in (54b), where the family name must be singular in form.

- (54) a. Mis primos {los músicos / *el músico} tocaron en mi boda.
 my cousins the musicians the musician played.3PL in my wedding
 ‘My cousins the musicians played at my wedding.’
 b. Mis primos {Herrero / *Herreros} tocaron en mi boda.
 my cousins Herrero Herreros played.3PL in my wedding
 ‘My Herrero cousins played at my wedding.’

In *mis primos los músicos* ‘my cousins the musicians’, not only are *mis primos* ‘my cousins’ and *los músicos* ‘the musicians’ both individual-denoting expressions, but they also have the same referent. Moreover, they can appear in separate prosodic units, as in (55).

- (55) Mis primos, los músicos, tocaron en mi boda.
 my cousins the musicians played.3PL in my wedding
 ‘My cousins, the musicians, played at my wedding.’

In *mis primos Herrero* ‘my Herrero cousins’, on the other hand, it is not immediately clear how to account for the family name. Even if one were to posit that *Herrero* is somehow an individual-denoting expression, it would not have the same referent as *mis primos*, nor can it be isolated by a prosodic break in (56).

- (56) *Mis primos, Herrero, tocaron en mi boda.
my cousins Herrero played.3PL in my wedding
Literal: ‘My cousins, Herrero, played at my wedding.’

The same judgments apply to *los primos Herrero* ‘the Herrero cousins’ in (57), which confirms that *Herrero* is referentially and prosodically dependent upon *los primos* ‘the cousins’ as well.

- (57) a. Los primos {Herrero / *Herreros} tocaron en mi boda.
the cousins Herrero Herreros played.3PL in my wedding
‘The Herrero cousins played at my wedding.’
b. *Los primos, Herrero, tocaron en mi boda.
the cousins Herrero played.3PL in my wedding
Literal: ‘The cousins, Herrero, played at my wedding.’

It therefore cannot be the case that in *los primos Herrero*, or in *los señores Guevara* ‘the Guevara gentlemen’ and *las hermanas Mirabal* ‘the Mirabal sisters’ for that matter, the family name occurs in apposition to the definite description.

Based on the data in (57), I propose that *los primos Herrero* ‘the Herrero cousins’ constitutes a single definite description, one in which *Herrero* is a PP modifier of *primos* ‘cousins’, as in (58).¹⁴

- (58) [_{DP} *los* [_{DivP} *primos*] [_{PP} Ø [_{nP} *Herrero*]]]
‘the Herrero cousins’

Since *Herrero* is the object of a preposition, there is no expectation that it would display number concord with the noun that it modifies. To explain the same lack of plural marking on this family name in *los Herrero* ‘the (unrelated or related) Herreros’, all that is needed is to posit an unpronounced head noun, as in (59).

- (59) [_{DP} *los* [_{DivP} Ø] [_{PP} Ø [_{nP} *Herrero*]]]
‘the Herrero ones’

In the next part of this section, I attribute the reading ‘the (unrelated) Herreros’ to a covert light noun and the reading ‘the (related) Herreros’ to a covert kinship term.

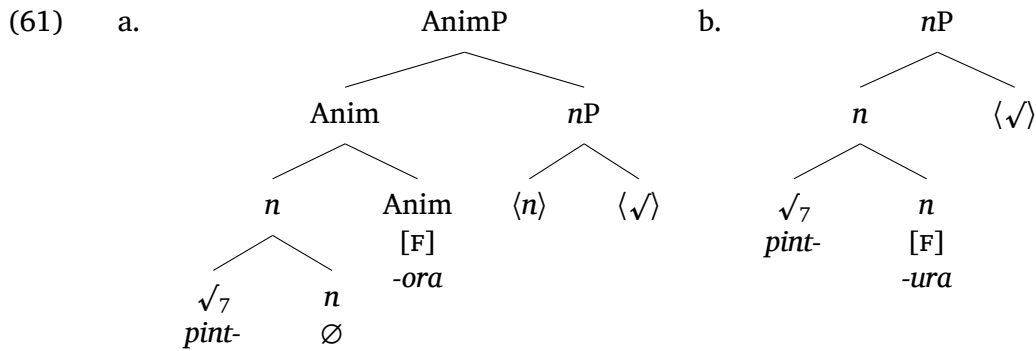
As represented in (59), *los Herrero* ‘the (unrelated or related) Herreros’ is structurally similar to *los de hierro* ‘the iron ones’, but there is a presupposition of animacy in the first expression that is not present in the second. One way to introduce animacy into the derivation is through an [ANIM(ATE)] feature on *n*, as in (60a), and another is through Panagiotidis’s (2019) animacy phrase (AnimP), as in (60b).

- (60) a.
$$\begin{array}{c} nP \\ | \\ n \\ [ANIM] \end{array}$$

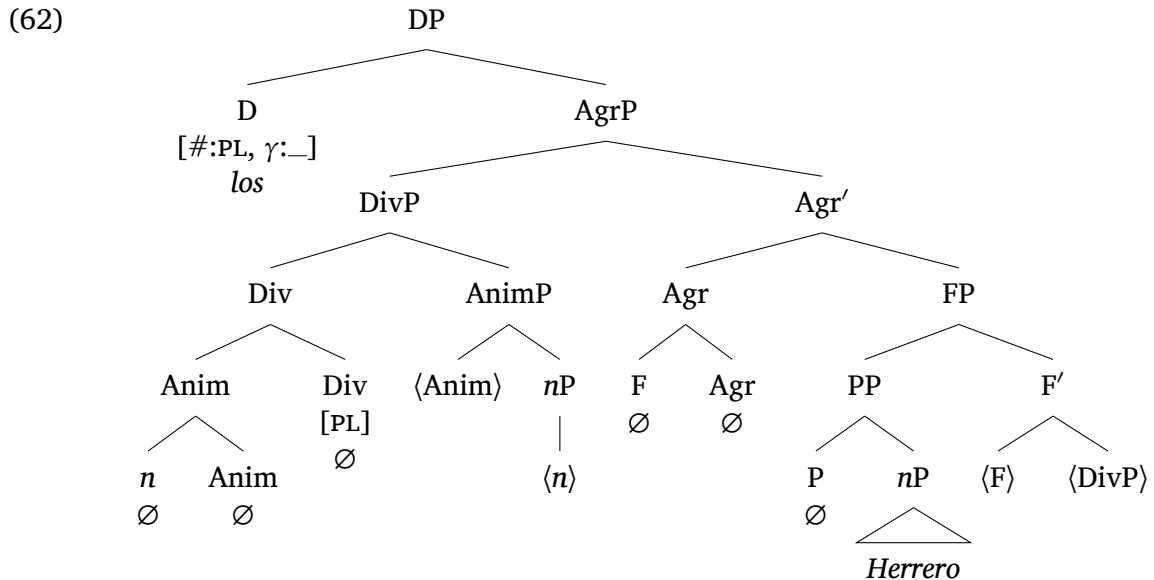
- b.
$$\begin{array}{c} AnimP \\ / \quad \backslash \\ Anim \quad nP \\ / \quad \backslash \quad | \\ n \quad Anim \quad \langle n \rangle \end{array}$$

¹⁴ I suspect that *Herrero* is an *aP* modifier in the English construction *the Herrero cousins* given that PP modifiers can only appear postnominally in this language: *the cousins in Hamilton*, but **the in Hamilton cousins*.

I opt for the second approach because it enables a principled account of the difference between gender that has consequences for interpretation and that which does not. For example, the nouns *pintora* ‘(female) painter’ and *pintura* ‘paint, painting’ are both feminine in Spanish, but only *pintora* presupposes femaleness. If, as Jambrović (2025) argues, [F(EMININE)] make a semantic contribution when it is subordinate to Anim, as in (61a), but not to *n*, as in (61b), one can forgo “interpretable” and “uninterpretable” versions of this feature (cf. Matushansky 2013; Kramer 2014, 2015; Anagnostopoulou 2017; Wurmbrand 2017a,b; Panagiotidis 2019; Smith 2021; Steriopolo 2024; Adamson 2025a,b; Adamson & Anagnostopoulou to appear).¹⁵



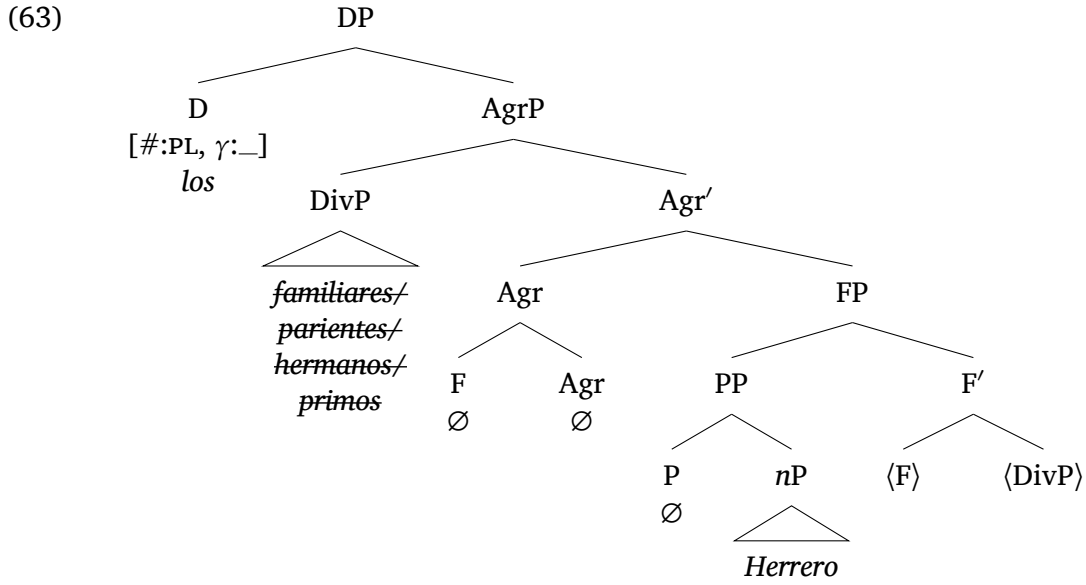
When *los Herrero* refers to a plurality of unrelated individuals who have the same family name, it has the structure in (62), where the rootless DivP can be construed as PEOPLE, the plural counterpart to Kayne’s (2004, 2008) light noun PERSON.¹⁶



When *los Herrero* refers to a plurality of related individuals, it has the nearly identical structure in (63), where DivP instead contains an elided noun like *familiares/parientes* ‘relatives’, *hermanos* ‘siblings’, or *primos* ‘cousins’ that is determined by the context.

¹⁵ This system can, furthermore, capture human-denoting feminine nouns that do not presuppose femaleness, such as *persona* ‘person’ and *víctima* ‘victim’, by representing them as AnimPs in which [F] is hosted by *n* rather than Anim.

¹⁶ There is no need for a [M(ASCULINE)] feature in *los Herrero* if one considers the “masculine” forms of the definite article to be underspecified for gender, as indicated by $\gamma:-$ on D.



The two readings of *las Herrero* ‘the (unrelated or related female) Herreros’ can likewise be derived by taking the relevant configuration in (62) or (63) and adding [F] to Anim.

To calculate the denotation of the structures in (62) and (63), it is necessary to start with the semantic value of each component. First, *nPs* that consist solely of a nominalizer are akin to Kayne’s (2004, 2008) light noun THING and have the interpretation in (64).

$$(64) \quad \llbracket nP \rrbracket = \lambda x_e . \text{Object}(x)$$

Second, Anim has the lexical entry in (65), according to which it triggers a presupposition of animacy (Jambrović 2025: 134).

$$(65) \quad \llbracket \text{Anim} \rrbracket = \lambda P_{\langle e, t \rangle} . \lambda x_e : \text{Animate}(x) . P(x)$$

Third, as mentioned in section 2 and as formalized in (66), Div takes a predicate and returns its algebraic closure, or all possible sums of the elements in its extension, through Link’s (1983) star operator (*).

$$(66) \quad \llbracket \text{Div} \rrbracket = \lambda P_{\langle e, t \rangle} . \lambda x_e . *P(x)$$

When Anim applies a rootless *nP*, it yields the AnimP in (67a), which is equivalent to the light noun PERSON, and when Div applies to this AnimP, it yields the DivP in (67b), which is equivalent to the light noun PEOPLE.

$$(67) \quad \begin{array}{ll} \text{a. } \llbracket \text{AnimP} \rrbracket &= \lambda x_e : \text{Animate}(x) . \text{Object}(x) \\ \text{b. } \llbracket \text{DivP} \rrbracket &= \lambda x_e . *\text{Object}(x), \text{ defined only if } \text{Animate}(x) \end{array}$$

Fourth, I model the silent preposition that links family names to the head noun as a semantically vacuous identity function, as in (68), to enable predicate modification.

$$(68) \quad \llbracket P \rrbracket = \lambda P_{\langle e, t \rangle} . P$$

When the light noun PEOPLE combines with *Herrero*, the resulting AgrP has the denotation in (69a), and when a noun like *familiares* ‘relatives’ combines with this family name, the resulting AgrP has the denotation in (69b).

- (69) a. $\llbracket \text{PEOPLE Herrero} \rrbracket = \lambda x_e . *Object(x) \wedge /erero/(x)$,
defined only if $Animate(x)$
b. $\llbracket \text{familiares Herrero} \rrbracket = \lambda x_e . *Relative(x) \wedge /erero/(x)$,
defined only if $Animate(x)$

Finally, I adopt Heim's (2011: 998) lexical entry for the definite article in (70a) and definition of the maximality operator (MAX) in (70b).

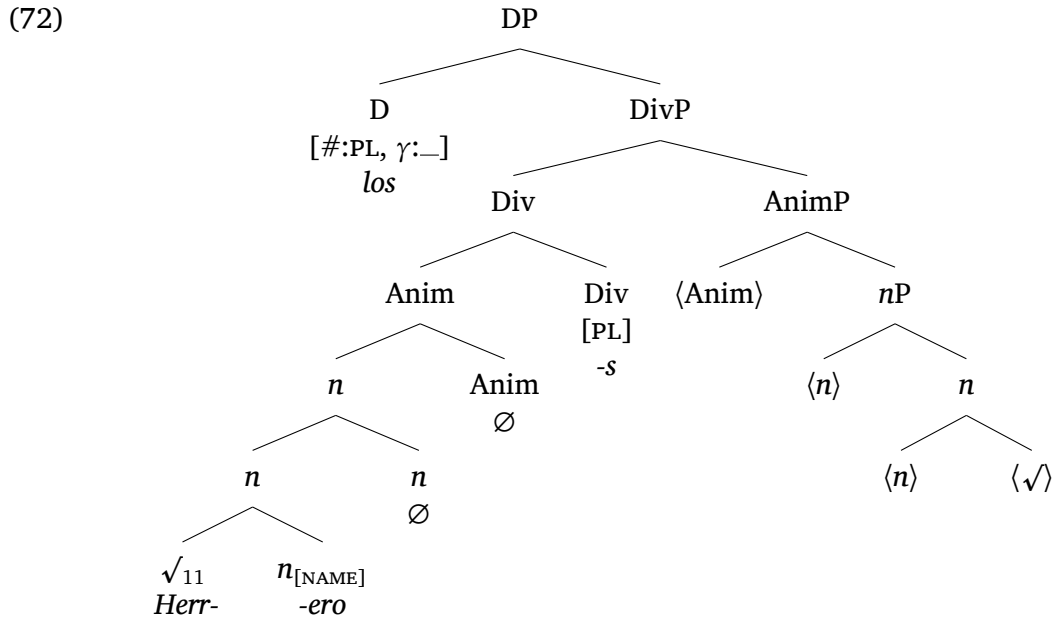
- (70) a. $\llbracket \text{the} \rrbracket = \lambda P_{\langle e, t \rangle} : \exists x_e \forall y_e [MAX(P)(y) \leftrightarrow x = y] . \iota x_e MAX(P)(x)$
b. $MAX(P) := \lambda x_e . P(x) \wedge \neg \exists y_e [P(y) \wedge x < y]$

In essence, the definite article presupposes that a unique maximal individual exists and then returns that individual. When *los* 'the' applies to the predicates in (69), it yields the definite descriptions in (71).

- (71) a. $\llbracket \text{los PEOPLE Herrero} \rrbracket = \iota x_e MAX(*Object \cap /erero/)(x)$,
defined only if $Animate(x)$ and $\exists x_e \forall y_e$
 $[MAX(*Object \cap /erero/)(y) \leftrightarrow x = y]$
b. $\llbracket \text{los familiares Herrero} \rrbracket = \iota x_e MAX(*Relative \cap /erero/)(x)$,
defined only if $Animate(x)$ and $\exists x_e \forall y_e$
 $[MAX(*Relative \cap /erero/)(y) \leftrightarrow x = y]$

The first expression, which maps onto the structure in (62), denotes a unique maximal sum of individuals who are people and bear the phonological string /erero/, and the second expression, which maps onto the structure in (63), denotes a unique maximal sum of individuals who are relatives and bear this same phonological string.

Turning to the construction *los Herreros* 'the (unrelated) Herreros', the plural marking on the family name indicates that it is the head of the noun phrase, as shown in (72).¹⁷



¹⁷ One could also represent *Herreros* as in (ii), where $n_{[NAME]}$ converts the AnimP *herrero* 'smith' into the phonological string /erero/.

(ii) $[DivP -s [AnimP \emptyset [nP \emptyset [n_{[NAME]} \emptyset [AnimP herrero]]]]]$

There is no position available in this structure for *familiares* ‘relatives’ or any other noun, so *los Herreros* cannot express a familial relation. This definite description has the semantic value in (73), which is equivalent to that of *los PEOPLE Herrero* in (71a) above.

- (73) $[[\text{los Herreros}]] = \iota x_e \text{MAX}(*\text{/erero/})(x),$
 defined only if $\text{Animate}(x)$ and $\exists x_e \forall y_e [\text{MAX}(*\text{/erero/})(y)$
 $\leftrightarrow x = y]$

Since *Herrero* contributes the property of bearing the phonological string */erero/* in both *los PEOPLE Herrero* and *los Herreros*, the difference between these constructions is purely syntactic. In the first, it is the light noun *PERSON* that is pluralized, and in the second, it is the family name *Herrero* that is pluralized.

It is now possible to explain why the given name in (5) above, repeated in (74), must be marked as plural even though the individuals in question are related.

- (74) Los {Alejandros / *Alejandro}, padre e hijo, trabajan juntos.
 the Alejandros Alejandro father and son work.3PL together
 ‘The Alejandros, father and son, work together.’

Intuitively, only family names can be modifiers, so there is a clash in **los Alejandro* ‘the Alejandro ones’, or **los familiares Alejandro* ‘the Alejandro relatives’, between the syntactic position that *Alejandro* occupies and the fact that it is not a family name in Spanish. There are some names that serve double duty, such as *Alonso* and *Martín*, but their interpretation is constrained by the structure in which they appear. For instance, it can only be understood from the sentence in (75a) that the father and son have the same given name, and it can only be understood from the sentence in (75b) that they have the same family name.

- (75) a. Los Alonsos, padre e hijo, trabajan juntos.
 the Alonsos father and son work.3PL together
 ‘The Alonsos, father and son, work together.’
 b. Los Alonso, padre e hijo, trabajan juntos.
 the Alonso father and son work.3PL together
 ‘The Alonsos, father and son, work together.’

Still, one would expect ambiguity in a situation that does not explicitly convey a relation among individuals because family names can head the noun phrase in such cases. This prediction is borne out in (76), where it is impossible to determine whether *Alonso* is a given name or a family name.

- (76) Hay varios Alonsos en la lista de invitados.
 has several Alonsos on the list of guests
 ‘There are several Alonsos on the guest list.’

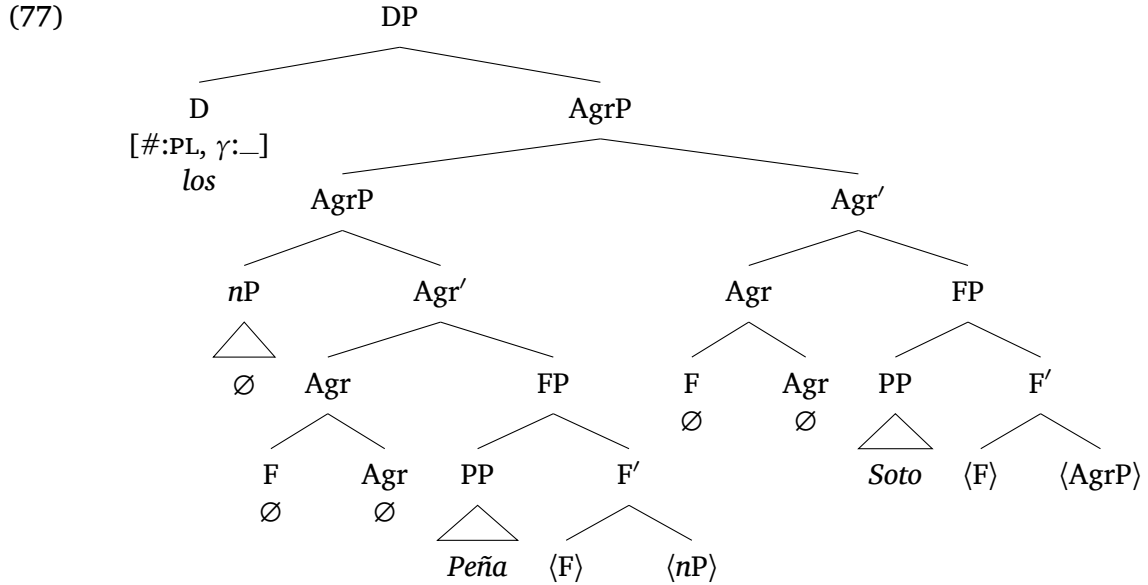
I conclude with the following generalization: family names can be modifiers or heads depending on the context, but given names can only be heads no matter the context.

6 Extensions of the analysis

In this penultimate section, I demonstrate how the account of family names that I have developed in this paper informs several open issues in the literature, including the struc-

ture of complex family names, the invariable forms of patronymic family names, and the inflectional behaviour of the names of dynasties.

As discussed in section 3, many Spanish-speaking individuals have two family names, so the question is where to position the second of these in the noun phrase. I propose that a definite description like *los Peña Soto* ‘the (unrelated or related) Peña Sotos’ has the representation in (77), where the family names *Peña* and *Soto* are PP modifiers of the covert head noun and their linear order is derived through successive roll-up movement.¹⁸



When used to refer to two or more siblings, *los Peña Soto* has the semantic value in (78), according to which this expression denotes a unique maximal sum of individuals who are siblings and bear the phonological strings /peña/ and /soʔo/.

$$(78) \quad \llbracket \text{los hermanos Peña Soto} \rrbracket = \iota x_e \text{MAX}(*\text{Sibling} \cap /peña/ \cap /soʔo/)(x),$$

defined only if $\text{Animate}(x)$ and $\exists x_e \forall y_e$
 $[\text{MAX}(*\text{Sibling} \cap /peña/ \cap /soʔo/)(y) \leftrightarrow x = y]$

If one were to reverse the order of *Peña* and *Soto*, as in (79), the resulting DP would be syntactically distinct but semantically equivalent because I am treating family names as intersective modifiers.

$$(79) \quad \llbracket \text{los hermanos Soto Peña} \rrbracket = \iota x_e \text{MAX}(*\text{Sibling} \cap /soʔo/ \cap /peña/)(x),$$

defined only if $\text{Animate}(x)$ and $\exists x_e \forall y_e$
 $[\text{MAX}(*\text{Sibling} \cap /soʔo/ \cap /peña/)(y) \leftrightarrow x = y]$

This outcome may seem problematic, but there are empirical reasons to suspect that naming conventions in Spanish, and in any other language, constitute extralinguistic knowledge and thus lie beyond the purview of syntax or logical form.

In many Spanish-speaking countries, parents have the right to decide the order in which their children’s family names appear, just as adults have the right to change this order, but in other Spanish-speaking countries, the law still mandates that the paternal family

¹⁸ I assume that conjoined family names, such as *Ortega y Gasset*, occupy the specifier and complement of a coordination phrase (CoordP) that is headed by *y* ‘and’ and is itself the specifier of an FP. Unlike Fábregas (2021), however, I do not consider all complex family names to have this structure.

name precede the maternal one.¹⁹ With these considerations in mind, one can devise a variety of scenarios in which *los Peña Soto* ‘the (unrelated or related) Peña Sotos’ and *los Soto Peña* ‘the (unrelated or related) Soto Peñas’ refer to the same set of individuals. For example, Alejandro Peña Soto and Fernanda Peña Soto could be siblings whose maternal family name is Peña, and they could immigrate to a country that requires them to order their paternal family name Soto first on all official documentation. In spite of their best efforts to maintain the original order of their family names in social settings, they could become known as *los Soto Peña* in the second country even as they remain *los Peña Soto* in the first, and either sibling could utter the sentence in (80).

- (80) Aquí nos conocen como los Soto Peña, pero allí somos los Peña Soto.
 here 1PL know.3PL as the Soto Peña but there are.1PL the Peña Soto
 ‘Here they know us as the Soto Peñas, but there we are the Peña Sotos.’

In another situation, Alonso Peña Soto and María Peña Soto could be twins whose paternal family name Peña precedes their maternal family name Soto. If both decide to change this order as adults, either one could utter the sentence in (81).

- (81) Ahora somos los Soto Peña, pero antes éramos los Peña Soto.
 now are.1PL the Soto Peña but before were.1PL the Peña Soto
 ‘Now we are the Soto Peñas, but before we were the Peña Sotos.’

The only way to capture the fact that *los Peña Soto* and *los Soto Peña* can be coreferential is to model family names as intersective modifiers, exactly as I have done in this article.

The next topic concerns patronymic family names like *Ramírez* and their inability to be overtly pluralized, even in contexts like (82) where other family names can be (Alcina Franch & Bleca 1975, Camacho 2021, Fábregas 2021).

- (82) a. Hay muchos {García / Garcías} en el directorio.
 has many García Garcías in the directory
 ‘There are many Garcías in the directory.’
 b. Hay muchos {Ramírez / *Ramíreces} en el directorio.
 has many Ramírez Ramíreces in the directory
 ‘There are many Ramírezes in the directory.’

The nature of this restriction is not immediately apparent in light of nouns like *alférez* ‘second lieutenant’ and *lápiz* ‘pencil’, which have the same phonological profile as *Ramírez* and do inflect for number: *alféreces* ‘second lieutenants’ and *lápices* ‘pencils’. Spanish does, nevertheless, exhibit a dispreference for consecutive stressed and unstressed syllables that both end in a fricative, as evidenced by the invariable plural forms of the nouns *tesis* ‘thesis’ and *virus* ‘virus’ in (83).

- (83) Las dos {tesis / *tésises} investigan los mismos {virus / *víruses}.
 the two thesis theses investigate.3PL the same virus viruses
 ‘Both theses investigate the same viruses.’

This type of sequence can be avoided with family names that end in -z because there is always the option to use them as modifiers of the light noun PEOPLE. It cannot, however,

¹⁹ There are, moreover, documented cases from the period of the Spanish Inquisition where individuals would order their maternal family name before their paternal family name to emphasize their Christian lineage. For example, the poet and cleric Luis de Góngora y Argote was born Luis de Argote y Góngora to Francisco de Argote and Leonor de Góngora.

be avoided with nouns that end in *-z* as they can only head the noun phrase. In short, one finds a plausible explanation for the contrast between *alféreces* and **Ramíreces* in the syntactic positions that are available to nouns versus family names.

I close with the names of dynasties, which one would predict to remain invariable in plural definite descriptions that refer to their members. Indeed, the tendency in the vast majority of cases is to only inflect the definite article: *los Alba* ‘the Albas’, *los Bonaparte* ‘the Bonapartes’, *los Borgia/Borja* ‘the Borgias’, *los Braganza* ‘the Braganzas’, *los Guisa* ‘the Guises’, *los Habsburgo* ‘the Habsburgs’, *los Saboya* ‘the Savoy’, and *los Trastámara* ‘the Trastámaras’, among many others. Although most of these names have origins in languages other than Spanish, they all end in a vowel and would therefore permit the addition of the plural suffix *-s*, so its omission is informative. I have only been able to identify two dynasties where the preference is to include plural marking on the name, which are *los Borbones* ‘the Bourbons’ and *los Capetos* ‘the Capetians’. Considering that the Bourbon and Capetian dynasties are no older than the Savoy dynasty and were also founded in modern-day France, it would be difficult to attribute their exceptionality to historical or geographical factors, so I assume that *los Borbones* and *los Capetos* are learned forms. As for *los Austrias* ‘the Habsburgs’, an expression that refers to the same house as *los Habsburgo*, sources fail to observe that *Austria* is not a family name. There is, consequently, no reason to expect that it would remain uninflected in this environment.

7 Conclusion

In this paper, I have argued that the absence versus presence of plural marking on family names in Spanish is a reflex of their position in the noun phrase. When family names are used as modifiers, as in *varios Ø Herrero* ‘several Herrero ones’, they are embedded in a prepositional phrase and do not display number concord with the head noun. When family names are the head noun itself, as in *varios Herreros* ‘several Herreros’, they raise to Div and take the plural suffix *-s*. On the basis of this structural distinction, I proposed that the ambiguity of *los Ø Herrero* ‘the (unrelated or related) Herreros’ stems from the possibility of a contentless versus contentful elided noun. When this expression contains the light, or rootless, noun PEOPLE, it is interpreted as ‘the (unrelated) Herreros’, and when it contains an unpronounced kinship term, it is interpreted as ‘the (related) Herreros’. Finally, *los Herreros* ‘the (unrelated) Herreros’ only has one reading because it is the family name, and not a covert kinship term, that is the head of the noun phrase.

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